

Traverse Manual

Audio Damage, Inc.

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System Requirements

The following table summarizes the operating system requirements and formats provided for Traverse. Traverse is a 64-bit plugin.

Operating System	Minimum Version	Formats
macOS	10.13	AAX, AudioUnit, CLAP, VST3; Intel and Apple Silicon
Windows	10.0 version 1607	AAX, CLAP, VST3
Ubuntu	18.0	CLAP, LV2, VST3
iOS (separate purchase)	iOS 12	AUv3

Demonstration Version

We encourage you to download and try the demonstration version of Traverse before purchasing it. The demo version of Traverse is the same as the regular version, but has the following limitations:

- Presets cannot be saved, nor can parameter values or other settings. This includes the information usually stored by your host DAW. If you save a DAW session with an instance of the demo version of Traverse, the plugin will revert to its default state when you reload the session.
- Traverse will cease to emit audio altogether 20 minutes after you add it to your DAW session. You can remove it and add it again, but it will revert to its default state.

If you purchase Traverse after using the demonstration version, simply run the installer provided to you after your purchase to replace the demo version with the full version.

Introduction

Traverse is Audio Damage's tape delay and distortion effect, the third member of the family that includes Ascent and Descent. Where those two plugins live in reverb territory, Traverse occupies the other end of the space: cassette character, tape delay, and noise, all in a single window.

The idea behind Traverse is to give you everything you need to make something sound like it came off a cassette tape or a vintage tape echo machine, without making you chain four separate utility plugins together. Drive your signal through a tape saturation model, set an echo time, add some hiss, and adjust the wet/dry balance. That's most of it.

What makes Traverse a little more interesting than a simple "lo-fi" plugin is its architecture. The tape-simulation effects sit *inside* the delay feedback loop, reproducing the topology used by machines like the Roland Space Echo. This means that every repeat passes through the full cassette character chain: the saturation, the tone shaping, the wow and flutter. However, if you're looking for something less colorful, a switch changes the signal routing to take the tape effects out of the feedback loop, putting them after the delay. This gives you a more traditional delay sound, with the tape character applied to the whole signal, but without the extra coloration on the repeats. It's like having two plugins in one.

Traverse joins Dubstation and Other Desert Cities in our tradition of delay effects with personality all their own. We hope that you enjoy using it as much as we enjoyed making it.

Installation

Traverse uses our custom plugin manager application for installation. Launch it as usual on your operating system of choice and you'll be presented with a window like this:

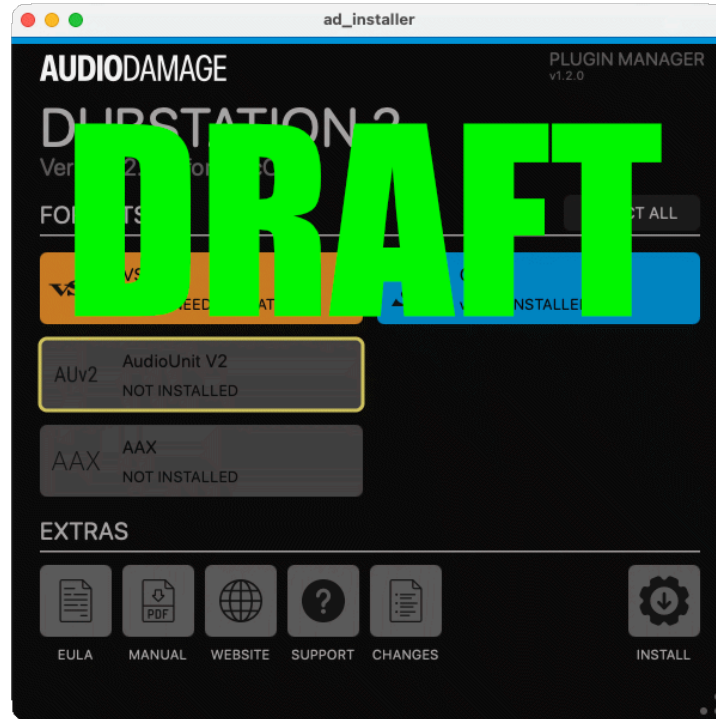


Figure 1: Screenshot of the installer window

Near the top of the window, beneath the name of the plugin, you'll see the version number of the software carried by the installer. This is distinct from the version of the plugin manager itself, which is shown in the upper right and usually not of much interest. (Note that the version numbers in this screenshot are for demonstration purposes only and may not reflect the actual version numbers of the software at the time you read this manual.)

Under the heading FORMATS are large buttons corresponding to the plugin formats which can be installed: AAX, AU, CLAP, LV2 and/or VST3, depending on the operating system. If the plugin is already present on your system in one or more formats (i.e. if you're upgrading from a previous version), the corresponding button is drawn in blue. When possible, the version number of the existing plugin is also shown. If the installer contains a newer version of the plugin than the one(s) already installed, the version number is drawn in orange to alert you to the fact that an update is available. If a format is not present on your system, its button is drawn in gray.

Click a button to select the format for installation. A yellow outline appears around the button to indicate that its format will be installed. In the above screenshot, VST3 and CLAP are installed, AAX and AudioUnit are not installed, VST3 is one revision behind that contained in the installer, and the AudioUnit is selected for installation. Clicking a button a second time removes the yellow outline, and the corresponding format will not be installed. Clicking the SELECT ALL button selects all available formats for installation.

No changes to your system's storage device take place until you click the INSTALL button near the lower-right corner of the window. Click that button and you'll receive visual confirmation that the formats you've selected have been installed. (Yes, it happens quickly. Our products are not encumbered by any DRM or anti-piracy baggage and hence install more quickly than many others.) On Windows and Linux, if you hold down the Shift key on your keyboard, the INSTALL button's label switches to UNINSTALL, and clicking it will remove the selected formats from your system¹. Once you're installed and/or removed the formats you need, simply close the application in the usual manner for your operating system. You're done. There is no license code or other authorization necessary; we'd rather assume we can trust you than burden you with an onerous DRM system.

You'll find some handy buttons under the EXTRAS heading, all of which are pretty self-explanatory:

- EULA: presents the End-User License Agreement for our products. By clicking the INSTALL button you're implicitly agreeing to these terms, but we expect that you'll find them reasonable should you take the time to read them.
- MANUAL: opens the current version of this user manual, in PDF form, in your web browser.
- WEBSITE: opens the product's web page in your browser.
- SUPPORT: displays information for contacting us, either via our Discord presence or through email.
- CHANGES: displays a summary of what we've added, changed or improved since the last version of the product.

¹ Blame Apple, not us, for the lack of this feature on macOS. On macOS just manually delete the plugin(s) from your plugin folder(s).

Operation

Traverse presents most of its controls in a single window, with a few additional controls tucked away in a secondary panel. The main window contains the tape character controls, the delay controls, the noise generator controls, and the global mix and output level controls. The secondary panel contains the wow, flutter, and splice controls that govern the tape modulation effects.

Here is a screenshot of Traverse, followed by detailed descriptions of its controls.



Signal Flow

The default signal path through Traverse is:

Input → Cassette Character → Tape Delay → Feedback loop → Mix → Output



Within the feedback loop, the delay output feeds back into the cassette input, so each successive echo is re-shaped by Drive, Tone, and any wow/flutter modulation you have dialed in. The **POST DELAY** button reverses the cassette and delay positions:

Input → Tape Delay → Cassette Character → Feedback loop → Mix → Output

In Post Delay mode, the plugin behaves more like a conventional delay with cassette coloration applied to the echoes. The direct signal is not processed by the cassette chain at all — only the delay tail is.

Controls

Top Bar

The top bar follows the standard Audio Damage family layout: logo (also the About button) at the far left, preset browser in the center, and **SETTINGS** and **BYPASS** at the right.

Logo / About Button Clicking the Traverse logo in the upper left opens the About screen, which displays version information and credits.

Preset Browser The preset browser in the top center displays the name of the currently loaded preset. Clicking the browser area opens the full preset panel, where you can browse factory and user presets, save new presets, and organize favorites. The left and right arrow buttons on either side of the browser name step through the preset list in order.

Favorite Star The star button to the right of the preset browser marks the current preset as a favorite (or removes the mark if it is already favorited).

SETTINGS Opens the Settings panel, which contains options for oversampling and mains hum region (50Hz or 60Hz, relevant to the Mains Hum noise type). See the Settings section below.

BYPASS Bypasses all processing with a smooth 50ms crossfade. The bypass state is saved with the preset. When Bypass is engaged, the button illuminates. Note that the **Mix** knob does not affect the bypass crossfade — Bypass always crossfades to the fully dry signal regardless of where Mix is set.

Cassette Character Section

DRIVE Controls the amount of cassette saturation. Traverse's cassette model is built around a physics-based tape hysteresis simulation rather than a static waveshaper, which means Drive affects both the tonal character and the dynamic response simultaneously — more Drive gives you more soft-knee compression alongside more harmonic saturation. At low settings, the cassette chain adds subtle warmth. As you turn Drive clockwise, the behavior becomes progressively more like an overloaded cassette: compressed, harmonically dense, and increasingly distorted at signal peaks. At minimum Drive, the cassette chain still processes your signal — it does not collapse to silence.

TONE A bipolar tilt equalizer that pivots around 1kHz. Fully anti-clockwise gives a progressively darker character; fully clockwise gives a progressively brighter one. Center position (12 o'clock) is flat. Tone sits inside the cassette signal chain and the feedback loop, so its character accumulates across echoes: a dark Tone setting with high Feedback produces repeats that grow increasingly dull with each pass, which is exactly what happens on an old machine with worn heads.

POST DELAY (button) Routes the cassette processing after the tape delay rather than before it. When this button is off (the default), your input signal passes through the cassette character chain first, then enters the delay. When POST DELAY is on, the input goes directly into the delay, and the cassette chain processes only the delay output. The practical difference is significant: in the default routing, your dry "first hit" is shaped by the cassette, and so is every echo. In Post Delay mode, the first hit passes through clean (relative to the wet/dry Mix setting), and only the echoes get the cassette treatment.

TAPE FX (button) Opens the Tape FX sub-panel, which contains the cassette modulation and splice controls. Click TAPE FX again (or click anywhere outside the panel) to close it.

Tape FX Panel

The Tape FX panel is accessed via the **TAPE FX** button in the main window. It contains six controls governing the tape machine's mechanical character: wow, flutter, and the splice system.

WOW Controls the depth of the slow, low-frequency pitch modulation that results from variations in tape transport speed. On a real cassette machine, wow is caused by irregularities in the capstan, pinch roller, and supply reel — variations slow enough that you hear them as gradual pitch drift rather than vibrato. Fully anti-clockwise is no wow modulation. Turning clockwise increases the depth of the drift. At high settings, the pitch wanders noticeably and continuously.

FLUTTER Controls the depth of the faster pitch modulation caused by short-term speed variations: motor cogging, head-to-tape friction, and reel imbalance at higher frequencies. Flutter is perceived as a wavering or “warbling” quality. Like Wow, it is set to zero at the fully anti-clockwise position and increases clockwise. At high Flutter settings with high Feedback, the modulation accumulates across echoes and can become a thick, chorused texture.

SPLICE (rate control) Splice events are simulated tape dropout events — brief moments where the tape loses contact with the heads, producing a short dip in level and a chirp in pitch. The Splice knob controls how frequently these events occur. Fully anti-clockwise produces the most frequent splices (one every half-second or so); turning clockwise makes them increasingly sparse, up to approximately one per minute at the fully clockwise position. Most of the knob's useful range is in the anti-clockwise half, where small changes produce audible differences in density.

DEPTH Controls the severity of each splice event — how much the level drops during a dropout. At minimum, splices are nearly inaudible. At maximum, each event produces a pronounced dip. Splice Depth interacts with the Drive setting: a higher Drive level means the cassette output is compressed and harmonically saturated, which makes the amplitude dips of individual splices somewhat less dramatic relative to the overall level.

PITCH (toggle) When on, splice events include a brief pitch chirp — a momentary variation in tape speed as the dropout occurs. This is the more characteristic sound of a cassette splice, where the head losing and regaining contact causes a tiny speed instability. When off, splices produce only the amplitude dropout with no pitch component.

AMP (toggle) When on, splice events include the amplitude dropout (the level dip). When off, only the pitch chirp occurs (if Pitch is also on). With both Pitch and Amp off, the splice system is effectively silent.

Tape Delay Section

TIME Sets the delay time. In free mode (Sync off), Time is displayed in milliseconds and covers the range from 20ms to 10 seconds. Most of the knob's travel is concentrated in the sub-2-second range where delay is most commonly used for rhythmic effects; the upper portion of the range spans the longer ambient territory. Because this is a tape delay model, changing Time while audio is playing produces a Doppler-style pitch shift as the effective read head position moves — the pitch rises as you shorten the time and drops as you lengthen it. This is not a defect; it is a characteristic of tape echo machines, and it is part of the sound.

When Sync is on, Time snaps to host-tempo beat divisions and the display shows the selected note value rather than milliseconds.

SYNC (button) Locks the delay time to your host's tempo. When Sync is engaged, the button illuminates and the Time knob steps through note values — including straight, dotted, and triplet divisions — rather than freely varying the millisecond value. Changes to the host tempo update the delay time automatically. Sync transitions are smooth; switching between free and synced modes does not produce clicks.

If you turn on the TEMPO SYNC switch Dubstation uses the current tempo reported by your host application to calculate its delay time. When this switch is on, the time knob sets the delay length in metrical units, that is, fractions of a beat. The range of values is 1/32nd to 1/1 (a whole measure), with dotted and triplet times available. Watch the value displayed below the knob as you rotate it to choose a delay interval—or just do it by ear. Triplet values are denoted with a T after the beat fraction, and dotted values are denoted with a period. For example, “1/8.” indicates a delay time with a dotted eighth note feel. Dubstation will track tempo changes, saving you from having to adjust its delay time by hand when you change the tempo of your song.

FEEDBACK Controls how much of the delay output feeds back into the input for the next repeat. At minimum, each echo plays once and fades. As Feedback increases, the echoes sustain longer. Because the delay sits inside the cassette feedback loop, high Feedback settings cause the cassette saturation, Tone, and Wow/Flutter modulation to accumulate across repeats — each successive echo is shaped by the full cassette chain again. At maximum Feedback, the loop approaches self-oscillation and the plugin will sustain indefinitely (or grow, depending on Drive and signal level).

WIDTH Controls ping-pong — the alternation of echoes between the left and right channels. Width is a bipolar control: center position (12 o'clock) produces no ping-pong, with each channel echoing itself independently. Turning clockwise from center increases ping-pong with the first echo landing on the right; the echoes then alternate left-right-left-right from there. Turning anti-clockwise from center produces the same ping-pong behavior with the first echo on the left. The magnitude of the deflection from center controls the amount of cross-feedback between channels — at the fully clockwise or fully anti-clockwise positions, feedback fully alternates between channels.

MENTION FEEDBACK AND WIDTH

Noise Generator

NOISE (knob) Controls the level of the generated noise signal, from silence at minimum to a prominent noise floor at maximum. The default preset has Noise set conservatively so that the plugin does not immediately announce itself as a noise machine. Noise is added into the cassette input path (before the delay), which means it is also processed by Drive, Tone, and Wow/Flutter, and it enters the feedback loop. At high Feedback levels, the noise accumulates in the feedback path and can build up significantly even from a low Noise setting.

Noise Type (selector) Selects the character of the generated noise. The selector shows the current noise type by name; clicking it opens the full list. The available types are:

- **Hiss** — tape hiss character: broadband noise with a high-frequency emphasis and a gentle shelf, resembling the background hiss of a cassette tape at normal bias.
- **Crackle** — vinyl crackle character: randomly timed impulse events of varying amplitude, similar to dust or scratches on a record surface.
- **Dust** — sparse amplitude dropouts triggered randomly, simulating moments where particles between the tape and head cause brief signal loss.
- **Fan Rumble** — low-frequency noise with slow amplitude variation, resembling the mechanical rumble of a motor or ventilation fan in proximity to the tape transport.

- **60Hz Hum** — mains electrical interference at 60Hz (North American standard), with harmonic content above the fundamental. The fundamental frequency can be changed to 50Hz in the Settings panel for European and other markets.
- **50Hz Hum** — mains electrical interference at 50Hz. (This entry and the 60Hz Hum entry both refer to the same noise generator; the frequency is controlled by the Mains Hum setting in the Settings panel. Both entries appear in the list for clarity.)
- **White** — spectrally flat white noise: equal energy per unit of frequency bandwidth. Brighter in character than tape hiss.
- **Pink** — pink noise: equal energy per octave, rolling off at roughly 3dB per octave above the low end. Perceptually more neutral than white noise and commonly used as a reference signal.
- **Card Reader** — a signature noise type combining the character of magnetic stripe card readers and similar contact-head devices: a mixture of hiss and intermittent high-frequency transients.

GATED (button) When Gated is on, the noise level drops by approximately 20dB whenever the input signal falls below the gate threshold. When signal is present, the noise plays at the level set by the Noise knob. When the input falls silent (below roughly -40dB), the noise attenuates — the gate uses a fast attack and a slower release to follow the signal naturally without chopping. This makes the noise feel “of the signal” rather than a constant floor: it rises with the music and falls away in the gaps. Gated is most useful at higher Noise settings where an unconditional noise floor would become distracting in silent passages.

Global Controls

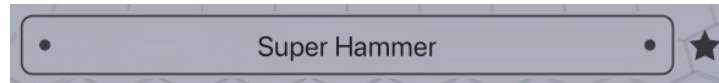
MIX Dry/wet balance. Fully anti-clockwise is 100% dry signal with the processed signal entirely silent; fully clockwise is 100% wet with no dry signal. The crossfade follows an equal-power curve so that the apparent level stays consistent through the sweep. The Mix knob affects both the cassette path and the delay; there is no way to separate them here (see the Out of Scope note below). Mix interacts with the **Mix Lock** feature described below.

Mix Lock (padlock icon) When the padlock is engaged, the Mix value is excluded from preset loading — it stays where you set it regardless of what preset you load. This is useful when you have dialed in a wet/dry balance that works for a particular session or instrument and you want to audition different presets without the Mix changing under you. When unlocked (the default), Mix loads with the rest of the preset parameters.

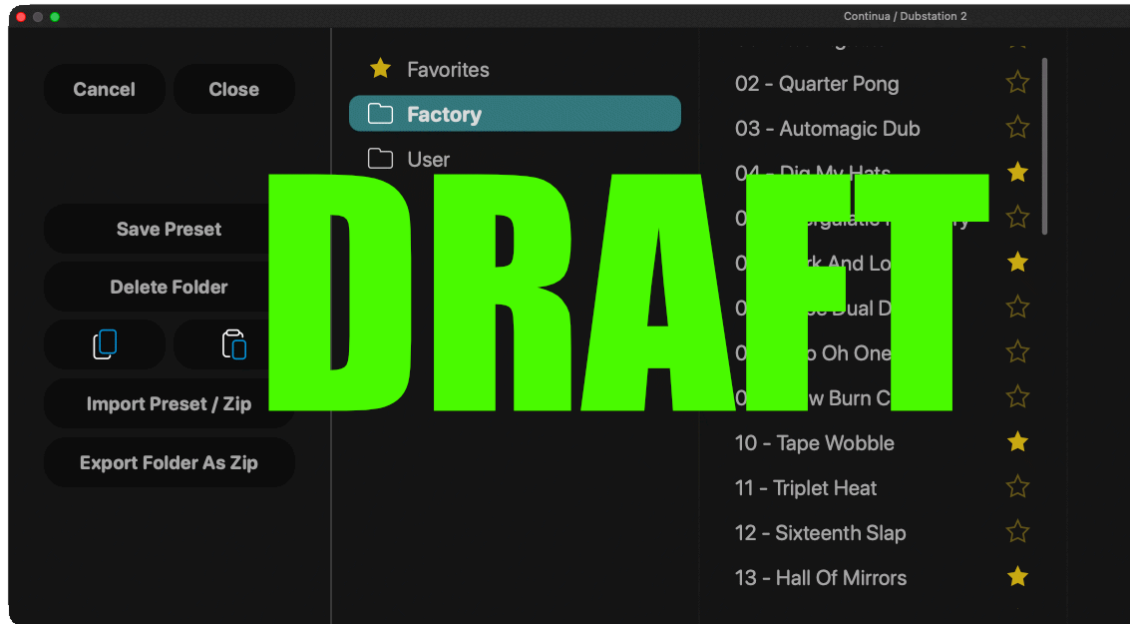
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Presets

Traverse includes a collection of presets to serve as a demonstration of its capabilities and inspirations for your own creations. There are a few controls at the top of the window associated with presets:



The name of the current preset appears in the center. (You probably figured that out yourself.) Clicking the little dots on the left and right loads presets in alphabetical order. Clicking the star outline marks the preset as a favorite to help you find it again in the future. To examine all of the presets, click the name of the current to open the preset browser.



The browser displays presets and folders in scrollable lists, arranged in columns. The leftmost list shows the folders within Traverse's preset collection, grouped in two categories: Factory and User. Clicking any of these folders reveals its contents in the next list. Clicking on a preset name loads the settings into Traverse. Click the CLOSE button in the preset browser to dismiss it. If you click the CANCEL button instead, the browser closes and Traverse's settings revert to their previous state. Double-clicking a preset name loads the preset and dismisses the preset browser. Loading a preset irretrievably erases the current settings, so if you have created something that you want to use again, save it as a new preset before loading another preset.

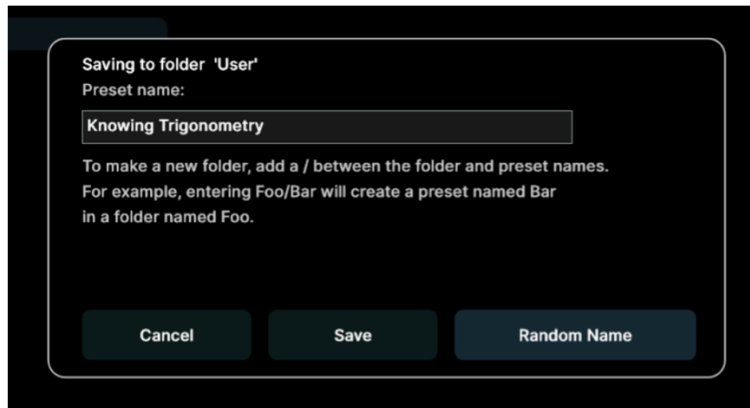
Once you have clicked on any item in the panel, you can navigate within the preset browser with the keys on your keyboard. The left and right arrow keys move the selection between columns, and the up and down arrow keys move it within the list. Tapping the ESC key has the same effect as clicking the Cancel button.

Just like the star at the top of the window which we mentioned previously, the stars to the right of preset names mark presets as favorites. Clicking a filled star removes the mark from a favorite. Once you've marked at least one favorite, a correspondingly named category appears in the leftmost column. Clicking it shows you all the presets you've marked, and clicking their names loads them as usual.

The folders and presets in the browser correspond to folders and files within Traverse's own folder on your storage device (i.e. your computer's hard drive or SSD). This folder is located at `C:\ProgramData\Audio Damage\Traverse\` on Windows, and `~/Music/Audio Damage/Traverse/` on macOS and Linux. You can store your presets anywhere you like, but for them to show up in the User list they must be placed in the User folder within Traverse's folder. Also, to avoid possible collisions during future updates, do not store your presets within the Factory folder.

Any folders you create within the User folder will show up as folders in the User list. You can create sub-folders within the User folder, and sub-folders within those folders. You can't nest folders deeper than that because the preset browser has only four lists.

To save your presets, click the SAVE PRESET button at the left edge of the window. This invokes a dialog box with a couple of helpful features. As the text therein describes, you can create a folder within the destination folder (whose name is given at the top of the dialog box) by adding the folder's name to the beginning of the preset's name, separated by a slash mark.



Clicking the RANDOM NAME button replaces the preset's name with a pair of words chosen at random from two lists. While the resulting names won't have any connection with what the plugin is doing, you may find this feature useful for coming up with alternatives to routine names like "My Preset 12".

Potential pitfall: once you've saved a preset, clicking its name in the list loads the preset, overwriting whatever changes you've made since you saved the preset. Hence if you want to save the preset again to preserve the changes you've made, do not click on its name before saving it.

You can delete presets and folders from the lists by clicking their name and then clicking the DELETE PRESET or DELETE FOLDER button. Traverse will give you a chance to confirm this action or cancel it. If you confirm, the preset/folder will be removed from your storage system and is gone for good.

Importing and Exporting Presets

Preset files are plain-text XML files so that you can exchange them online in forums, copy them between a Windows computer and a Macintosh (and even between an iPad and a regular computer), email them to your friends, etc.

The two buttons with icons representing copying and pasting (copy on the left, paste on the right) copy Traverse's current settings to the system clipboard and paste settings from the clipboard. You can use the copy and paste commands to transfer settings between two instances of Traverse or paste the settings into an email message or text editor. When copied to the clipboard, presets are presented in the same XML text as used in preset files.

The IMPORT PRESET/ZIP button provides a way to add presets to Traverse without manually moving them into the appropriate folders in your file system. Clicking this button produces a file-browser window wherein you can select either a single preset file or a .zip file containing one or more presets. After you select the file, Traverse copies the preset(s) into whichever folder you have selected in Traverse's preset list, unzipping the file first if necessary.

Depending on whether you've selected a preset or folder, the EXPORT SINGLE PRESET or EXPORT FOLDER AS ZIP button performs the complementary functions of the Import button. First select either a preset or a folder in Traverse's list, then click the export button. A file-save window appears; choose a location in your file system, give the file a name, and click SAVE. If you have chosen a folder in Traverse's preset list, the plugin places it and all of the presets it contains in a .zip file.

Default Preset

If you save a preset with the special name "Default" in the User folder, new instances of Traverse will load it automatically when you add it to your DAW session. You can use a default preset file to give yourself the same starting point with Traverse whenever you use it. The plugin installer creates a default preset file for you but feel free to replace it with your own.

And Finally...

Thanks for purchasing Traverse. We make every effort to ensure your satisfaction with our products and want you to be happy with your purchase. Please write to support@audiodamage.com if you have any questions or comments.

Document Revisions

- 2026-05-19: Initial draft for version 1.0

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